

A Borrowed Recovery?

The 2025 Teacher-Workforce Data for the United States

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The teacher exodus is over. In the year to 2025, 7.9 percent of American public school teachers left education. The average over the fifteen years before the pandemic was 7.7 percent; at the height of the disruption the rate hit 10.4. Every age group has drifted back to its own historical norm. After five years of headlines about burned-out teachers fleeing the profession, the 2025 data sound the all-clear.

I believe the number. I do not believe the all-clear, and this essay explains why. Nothing about teaching got better in 2025. Teacher pay stands further behind the graduate labor market than at any point since 2010. The flow of teachers out of the classroom into the jobs next to it is the widest on record. The typical new recruit is a forty-two-year-old career changer, and the workforce just shrank for the first time since the pandemic trough. What changed is the world outside the school building: the coldest hiring market in a decade has quietly done the work that pay and working conditions were supposed to do. Retention is being rented from the business cycle. Rentals get recalled.

Fewer pupils, and now fewer teachers

Start with demography, the slowest-moving piece. American public schools have been losing students since the fall of 2019, when enrollment peaked at 50.8 million. Smaller birth cohorts and the pandemic exodus have since removed 1.4 million pupils, and the official projections point further down. For five years the teaching workforce ignored this. It dipped in 2021, recovered, and by 2024 stood near its 2019 peak of 4.6 million. Fewer children, same teachers: pupil-teacher ratios improved without anyone designing it (Figure 1).

In 2025 the workforce caught up with its students. The stock of qualified teachers fell from 4.54 to 4.37 million, a drop of 3.7 percent, the sharpest one-year decline in the series outside the pandemic itself. Some adjustment had to come. Districts staffed up on federal relief money, the money has run out, and letting attrition shrink the payroll is how a school system downsizes without ever using the word layoff. A workforce falling in step with its student body is not alarming on its own. The alarming part is the composition of the flows underneath, which is where the rest of this essay lives.

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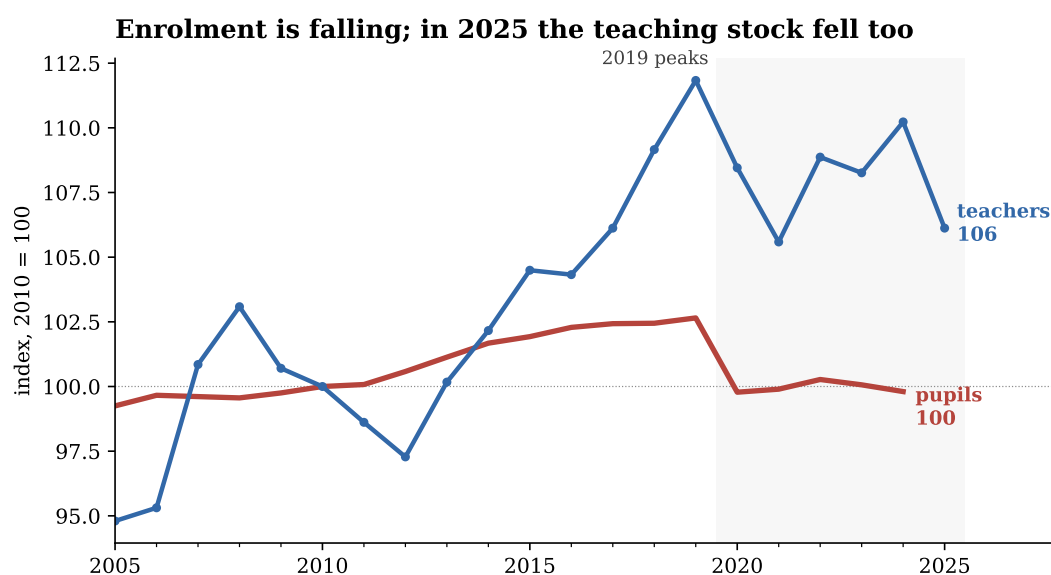


Figure 1: Public-school pupils and full-time qualified teachers, indexed to 2010.

Teachers: CPS monthly data, employed K–12 teachers (occupations 2310–2330) with at least a bachelor’s degree, annual average of weighted monthly stocks; survey estimates carry sampling error of roughly ± 1 –2 percent. The 2025 average covers eleven months, because no CPS was collected in October 2025 during the federal shutdown; the like-for-like eleven-month figure for 2024 (4.52M) confirms the decline is not an artefact. Pupils: NCES, Digest of Education Statistics, table 203.10, fall enrollment in public schools.

Two ways to leave a classroom

There are two honest ways to count a lost teacher. The narrow way asks whether she still works anywhere in education. The broad way asks whether she is still a classroom teacher. The distinction sounds like accounting. It turns out to be the whole story of 2025 (Figure 2).

Counted the narrow way, the crisis is over. The 7.9 percent who left education in 2024–25 is statistically indistinguishable from the long-run norm. The age profile has settled with it: the under-35s, whose exits spiked hardest after 2020, are back near their own rate, and so are the mid-career group and the over-fifties, whose line is permanently the highest because it carries retirements (Figure 3).

Counted the broad way, the crisis did not end. It changed address. Last year 13.3 percent of public school teachers left the classroom, still two points above the pre-pandemic norm, and the wedge between the two lines of Figure 2 reached 5.3 percentage points, the widest in the twenty years I can measure. Before the pandemic it averaged 3.4. Two of every five teachers who left a classroom last year never left education. They became instructional coaches, deans, counselors, tutors, college instructors. In the sector’s statistics this is churn, invisible in the numbers that make headlines. In the school it is the same empty desk at the front of the same room, and the person who used to stand at it is often down the hall, earning a little more to teach nobody.

The new teacher is forty-two

Attrition is half of the ledger. Replacement is the other half, and it is the half that looks least like a recovery. The median teacher who entered an American classroom between 2024 and 2025 was forty-

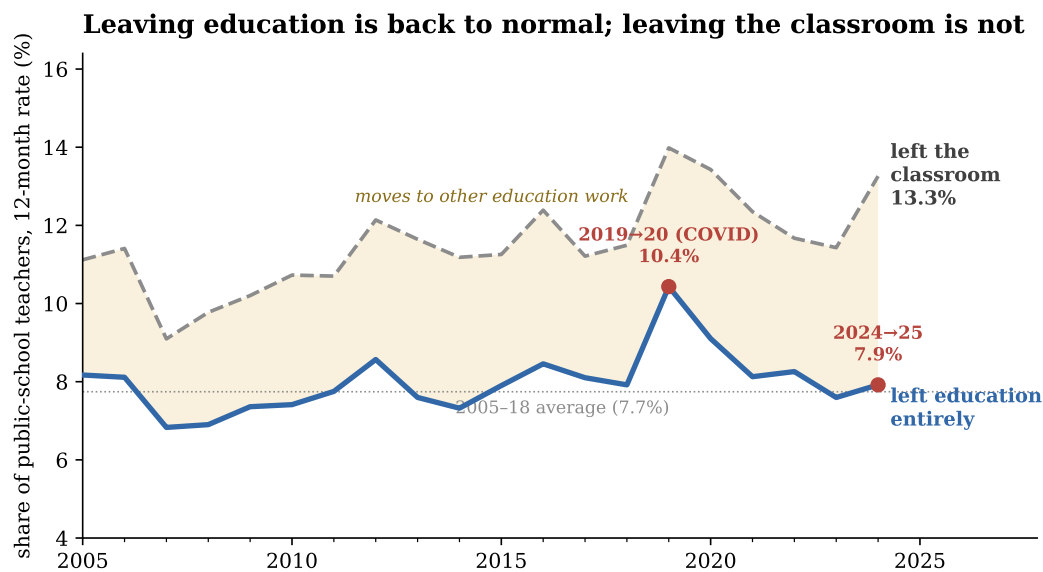


Figure 2: Two ways to leave: out of the classroom, and out of education.

Public-school full-time K–12 teachers with a bachelor’s degree or more, followed twelve months in linked CPS interviews, 2005–2024 base years ($n = 91,035$; 2,841 in 2024, which lacks October links because no October 2025 survey exists). Blue: working in no education occupation at $t+12$ and not teaching in any later interview. Dashed: no longer a classroom teacher by the same standard. The gap between the lines is movement into other education work.

two years old. Three quarters arrived straight from another job, 18 percent from outside the labor force, and fewer than one in five was under thirty. Entries replaced 16.6 percent of the stock while exits took 20.3, which is the arithmetic behind the shrinking workforce of Figure 1. The profession is aging from the entry door: teachers under thirty-five were 32 percent of the workforce in the mid-2000s and are 29 percent today.

Career changers are not worse teachers. A profession that can pull in a forty-two-year-old engineer is healthier than one nobody re-enters, and about one apparent leaver in six is back in a classroom within months, a revolving door that softens every flow in this essay. But hire a twenty-five-year-old and you buy, in expectation, three decades of teaching; hire a forty-two-year-old and you buy half that. And the career changer is, by definition, a person comparing two careers in real time. She responds to relative pay the way a thermostat responds to temperature. So what has happened to relative pay?

The pay that never came back

A teacher at the median earned \$1,380 a week in 2025. Her counterpart in 2010 earned \$1,462, in the same 2025 dollars. Fifteen years of budgets, strikes and salary schedules have left the median American teacher 5.6 percent poorer in real terms, while the median full-time worker gained 9 percent and the median college graduate gained 3 (Figure 4). Measured against the graduate market in which teaching actually recruits, teacher pay has slid from 87 cents on the graduate dollar to 79. The inflation surge did the worst of it: between 2021 and 2023 teachers lost nearly 6 percent of their real weekly pay, and the rebound since has clawed back less than half.

Which leaves a puzzle. Teaching pays relatively worse than at any point in fifteen years. The classroom is leaking into the back office at a record rate. And yet attrition from the sector sits exactly on its long-run

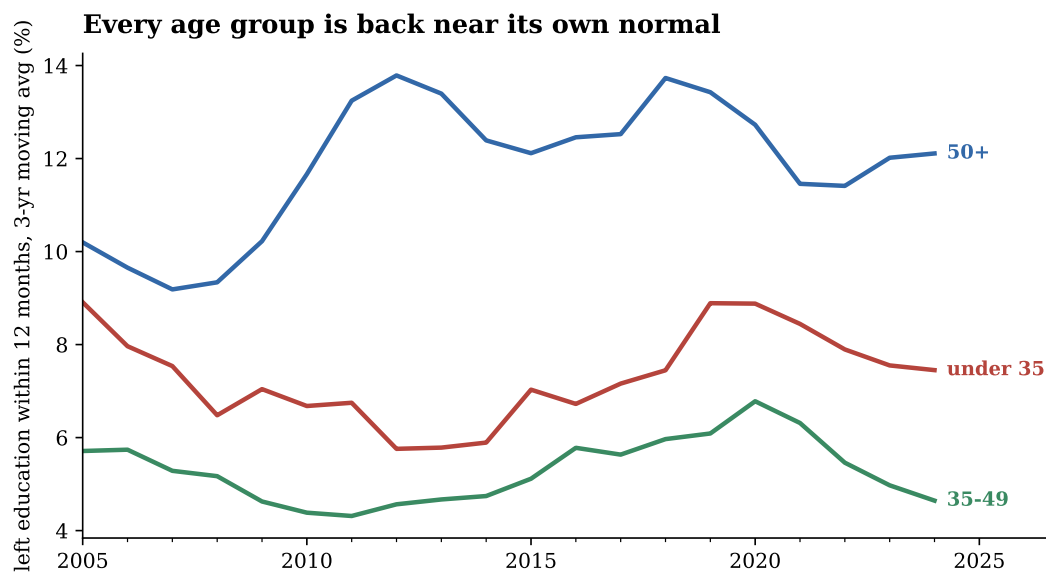


Figure 3: Attrition from education by age of teacher.

Same universe and definition as the blue line of Figure 2, split by age at the base interview; three-year centered moving averages. The 50+ line embeds retirements and is structurally the highest.



Figure 4: Real median weekly earnings: teachers, all graduates, all workers.

Teachers: weighted median usual weekly earnings of full-time K–12 teachers (BA+), CPS outgoing-rotation interviews, deflated by CPI-U. Graduates: BLS median usual weekly earnings, bachelor's degree and higher, age 25+. All workers: BLS real median usual weekly earnings, age 16+. Indexed to 2010 = 100.

average. How can all three be true at once?

A recovery on loan

Because teachers are people, and people quit jobs when there are other jobs to go to. The left panel of Figure 5 plots the rate at which teachers leave education against the national unemployment rate, drawn

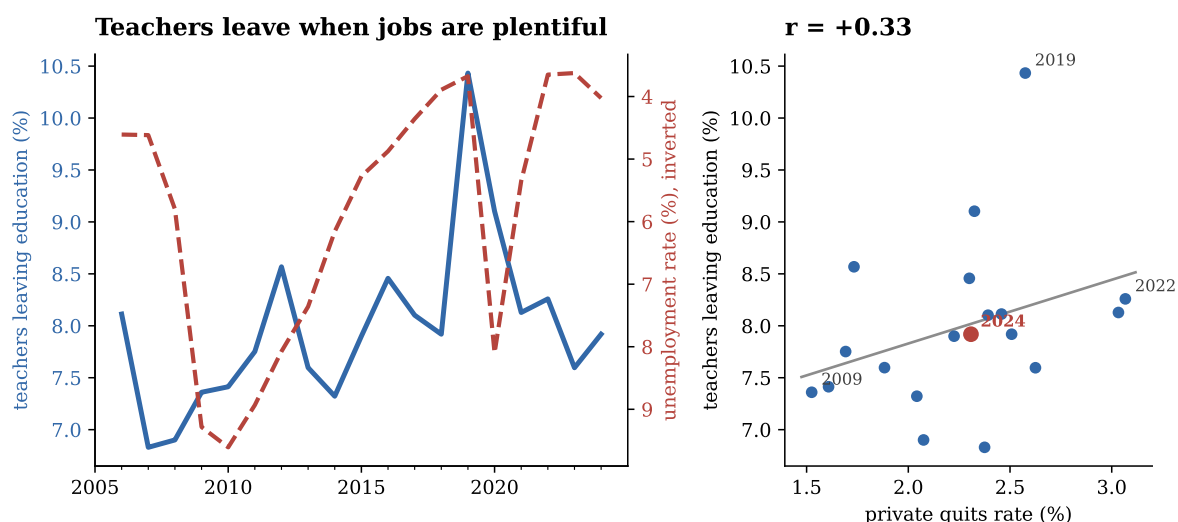


Figure 5: Teacher attrition and the outside labor market.

Left: teachers leaving education (as in Figure 2) and the national unemployment rate (right axis, inverted). Right: the same leaver rate against the private-sector quits rate (JOLTS, annual averages), with an OLS fit; the 2024 point lies on the line. The 2019 observation links into 2020 and carries the COVID shock.

upside down so that good times point up. The two lines breathe together. When unemployment reached ten percent after 2008, teacher attrition sat at the floor of its range. Through the long 2010s expansion both climbed. Both peaked in the overheated market of 2019, collapsed with COVID, and have now come down together. Against the private-sector quits rate, the economy's willingness to walk out of a job, the correlation over two decades is 0.33. Teachers quit when everyone quits.

Now look at what the market has been doing. Private quits have fallen from 3.1 percent a month in the 2022 frenzy to 2.3 percent. Hiring rates are at their lowest in a decade. Job openings per unemployed worker are back below their pre-pandemic level. Feed that 2.3 percent quits rate into the historical relationship and it predicts teacher attrition of almost exactly 8 percent. The observed rate is 7.9. The 2024 point in the right panel of Figure 5 sits on the fitted line, to the decimal.

This is the uncomfortable explanation for the good news. Normal attrition in 2025 is not evidence that teaching became more attractive; the pay series says plainly that it did not. It is evidence that the alternatives became less attractive, for now. The same fitted line implies that a return of quits to their 2022 level would push attrition back up by around half a point, and history says the young and the career changers, the margins already thinnest, move first. What the labor market has lent, the labor market can recall.

The window

Read quickly, the 2025 data close the book on the pandemic teacher crisis: attrition normal, every age group settled, ratios improving. Read carefully, they describe a workforce in remission rather than in health. The stock is falling. The classroom leaks into the jobs beside it at a record rate. New supply is old and thin among the young. Pay is eight points further behind the graduate market than in 2010. And the retention holding it all together is fully explained by a slow economy.

Of those five facts, school systems control exactly one: what teaching pays, and whether the classroom itself is a job worth keeping rather than a stepping stone to the jobs around it. A slack labor market is the

cheapest moment there is to fix pay, because retention does not need rescuing at the same time. That is the window the cycle has opened. The next boom will close it, and will then run the experiment of 2019 again on a workforce that is older, better paid everywhere else, and already halfway out the classroom door. The 2025 data are not the end of the story. They are the intermission.

A note on the data. Teacher series: CPS basic monthly microdata, January 2005 to December 2025 (Census Bureau; NBER mirror before 2021). The CPS re-interviews each address twelve months apart; persons are linked across interviews and validated on sex, race and age progression, following Madrian and Lefgren (2000). Attrition (Figures 2, 3 and 5) is measured on public-school full-time K–12 teachers, occupations 2310, 2320 and 2330, with a bachelor’s degree or higher, in base rotations that allow re-interviews. A leaver has left the classroom (dashed line) or every education-adjacent occupation (solid line) at $t+12$ and is not observed teaching in any later interview; this definition matches the public-school leaver rates of 7.6 to 8.0 percent in the NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey and the retrospective CPS literature (Harris and Adams, 2007; Aldeman and Yi, 2025). Stocks and earnings use the full K–12 universe including private schools, with final person weights throughout. External series: NCES Digest table 203.10 for enrollment; BLS via FRED for comparator earnings (LEU0252918500, LEU0252881600), quits (JTS1000QUR), unemployment (UNRATE) and the CPI-U deflator. No CPS was collected in October 2025 because of the federal shutdown, so 2025 stocks average eleven months and the 2024–25 links exclude October. Replication code: `src/30_borrowed_recovery_data.py` and `src/31_borrowed_recovery_figures.py`.

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